2 The Birth of Israel 1939–49

POINTS TO CONSIDER

The Jews in Palestine largely supported the British during the Second World War. Then, when it ended, they went on the offensive in order to end British rule in Palestine and achieve a state of their own. When the British finally left Palestine in 1948, the neighbouring Arab states invaded the new state of Israel. These developments are examined under the headings:

- Terrorism and the end of British rule
- Partition and civil war 1947–8
- The war of 1948–9

The chapter then goes on to consider, in the key debate, how Israel won the war.

Key dates

1942		Biltmore Declaration of support for a 'Jewish commonwealth' in all of Palestine
1945		Zionist conference decided on a policy of active opposition to British rule
1946		Attack on the King David Hotel in Jerusalem
1947		Hanging of two British soldiers by Irgun
		The Exodus prevented from landing in Palestine
1947	November	United Nations vote for partition of Palestine
	November	Start of civil war in Palestine
	December	British announcement that they would leave Palestine
1948	May 14	British withdrawal from Palestine
	May 14	Declaration of new state of Israel
	May 15	Invasion of Israel by Arab armies
1949	January	Final ceasefire arranged